

Killer Soup features Manoj Bajpayee playing the **DOUBLE ROLE** of Swati's (essayed by Sensharma) husband and that of her lover

2), acting in one (*Geeli Puchi* in the anthology *Ajeeb Daastaans*) and featuring in a web series (*Mumbai Diaries* I & II). "I'd rather do interesting content and portray interesting characters that people would ideally connect to than do theatrical for theatrical's sake," she says.

It's OTT again that enables Sensharma to tick three boxes in one go: act alongside Manoj Bajpayee for the first time, work with director Abhishek Chaubey, and headline a black comedy, *Killer Soup*. "No actor would say no to this. I greedily lapped it up," she adds. Sensharma's Swati is the spine of the Netflix original, which Chaubey bills as "the journey of a submissive housewife into a sociopath". "We're all victims of her ambition," says Bajpayee, who plays the double role of Swati's husband and that of her lover. The ambition is fairly simple—Swati wants to run a restaurant. But it's complicated by the inconvenient truth that she's a terrible cook and an ordinary woman who keeps getting ensnared in extraordinary circumstances that only complicate her quest.

For Chaubey, who co-wrote the show with Unaiza Merchant, Harshad Nalawade and Anant Tripathi, the series enabled him "to explore how power operates within the confines of a family". "When we talk about patriarchy and how women are mistreated in marriages, a lot of the time, our cinema takes an extreme view of it," he says. "It [patriarchy] operates in subtle ways, where it's death by a thousand different cuts. It's the everyday rudeness and dismissal; you don't treat the person with respect and dignity."

Killer Soup, though, is anything but a marital melodrama. Adversity leads to ingenuity as Swati is steadfast about her dream even as things go south for her. Much like the Coen brothers' *Fargo*, there is an undertone of humour and quirky characters within the construct of a crime thriller. It's a world that Chaubey was smitten by as he set aside two years to develop the show.

For Bajpayee, the show is a manifestation of his desire to work with Chaubey again after doing a small part in his last feature, *Sonchiriya* (2019). This time around, he gets to play not one but three parts. "There was a lot of work daily. The mind was never empty. At times, I was too confused," he notes. Like Sensharma, Bajpayee, too, is savouring the opportunities streaming affords him. "The kind of scripts, the directors coming to us [sic], they are exploring and experimenting," he says. "I wanted this content for so many years. This is what we [Sensharma and I] were meant for." ■

Suhani Singh



The platform, launched in September 2023, now features over 2,000 clips of India-based content

The platform was launched in September 2023, at the G20 summit in New Delhi, with a series of short films called *Planet India*. It now features over 2,000 clips of India-based content. The *Planet India* series, co-created by Pluc-TV and Mission Overstory and now streaming on Jio, tells moving and powerful stories of how real people have, with ingenuity and dedication, effected real change in their own local environment. Tackling food waste by using solar-powered driers, accelerated tree planting in urban areas, monitoring and saving the snow leopard, and farming seaweed are just some of the stories showcased. Colin Butfield, director of Open Planet and executive director of Studio Silverback, puts it like this: "If we want to change how the world views nature, how the world tackles climate change, and how we look after people, then we have to change the story—and the way we tell the story. Planet India is our attempt to do that."

Spearheaded by Indian content, Open Planet now features a growing library of high-quality footage from all over the world. It comes at a time when such open-access resources are vital if we are to change the story of how we live on this beautiful, fragile and endangered planet. ■

Anita Roy